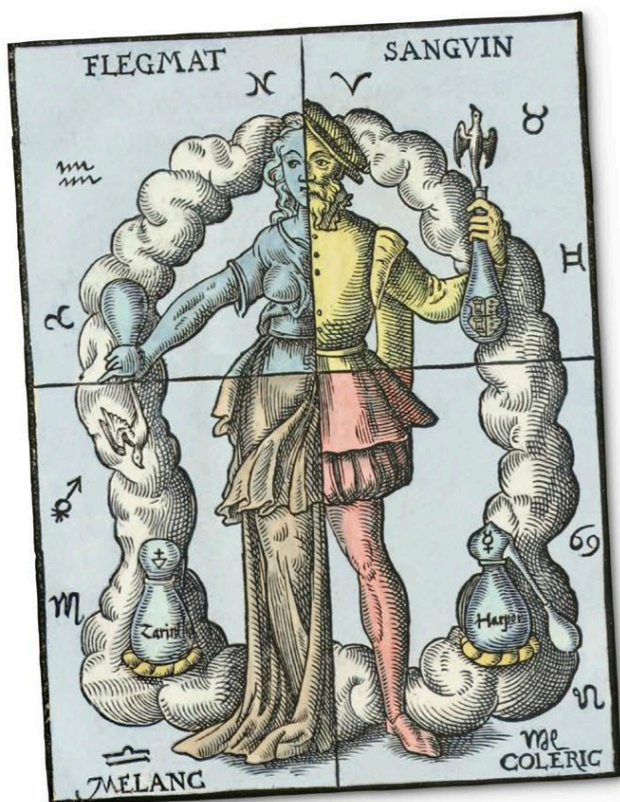




▲ Humors of the body

Much professional medicine tried to restore a balance between the humors, shown here clockwise from top left: phlegm, blood, yellow bile, and black bile. This medical practice was a far cry from rural healing methods and charms.

medical professionals—five nettle leaves provided courage, and mistletoe prevented a man from being condemned in court. The *Leechbook of Bald*, an 11th-century English medical text, describes a cure for dysentery that involved digging up a bramble root while singing the Lord's Prayer nine times, adding mugwort to the root, and boiling the plants in milk until the mixture turned red. Meanwhile, *Lacnunga* ("Remedies"), a similar compilation, blamed many afflictions on the mischievous workings of elves.

Amulets and charms continued to be widely used. While the 13th-century theologian St. Thomas Aquinas condemned these in his *Summa Theologica*, stating that scrolls contained within amulets or the writing engraved on talismans might be the names of demons, others were more accepting. Even some university doctors thought such methods could be effective: around 1300, Arnold of Villanova claimed to have used an astrological talisman to cure Pope Boniface VIII of kidney stones.

Medical astrology

It was common for medieval medicine to involve astrology; physicians and even churchmen accepted that heavenly bodies could exert influence on the earth. Indeed, by the end of the 13th century university-trained physicians were required to have studied medical astrology. When the French king

"Neither the first day of May nor the last day of September or April should blood be drawn, or goose be eaten."

REGIMEN SANITATIS SALERNITANUM, c. 12–13TH CENTURIES

example, one cure for patients with jaundice was to make a potion from mashed earthworms and stale urine in the belief that the yellow color of the ingredients would act against the yellow tint the disease gave to the sufferer's skin.

According to folk healers—a world away from

Philip VI convened the physicians of Paris in 1348 to provide an explanation for the Black Death, their report concluded that a conjunction of three planets in the sign of Aquarius three years earlier had caused the plague. Physicians routinely consulted horoscopes to find the auspicious days for surgery or courses of treatment, so much so that in 1437 a bitter controversy broke out in the University of Paris over the most propitious time for taking laxatives in January.

▼ Exorcizing illness

Here, St. Francis of Assisi cures a woman by casting out the demon thought to cause her sickness. Alongside professional medicine, exorcisms, prayers, and invocations to saints were believed to have the power to cure disease.

